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NITIN GUPTA, a 23-year-old engineering graduate from SVCE Nellore in Andhra Pradesh, received a job offer from Mindtree in April 2022 before its merger with L&T Infotech. Cut to August 2023, a year-and-a-half and multiple rounds of pre-onboarding training tests later, his offer has been revoked. Reason: He failed a pre-onboarding test in July 2023. "There is a disparity between the score my trainer gave me and what the management says I have scored. There is no clarity from them as to how the scores are different," says Gupta.

His plight is similar to that of several thousands of freshers from the 2022 and 2023 batches of engineering colleges who bagged jobs with IT services companies, on- or off campus, but are facing endless onboarding delays. If many have not heard back from their prospective employers about a joining date after being promised a job over a year ago, for others it is little solace when companies keep extending joining dates every two-three months. Still others have been compelled to undergo additional training even as their offer letters are nearing expiry, while some like Gupta have had their offers rescinded. They are essentially adrift in an uncertain tech job market.

After the euphoric days of 2021 up to September-October 2022 where the likes of TCS, Infosys, Wipro, HCL, Tech Mahindra, Cognizant, Accenture and several other IT firms hired freshers in droves

in anticipation of growth, they are now planning to cut back on hiring freshers due to a weak deal pipeline amid lingering recessionary fears in the US. Staffing firm TeamLease Digital has projected a 30 per cent year-on-year decline in FY24.

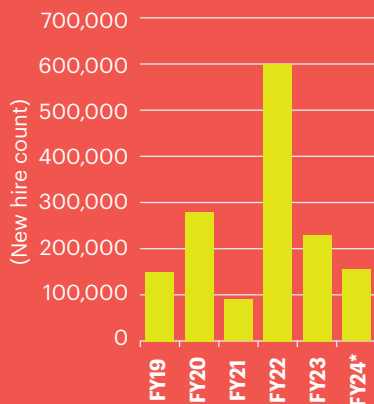
Harpreet Singh Saluja, President of Nascent Information Technology Employees Senate (NITES), estimates the employees' union has received complaints of onboarding delays from 20,000-25,000 students in the past two batches. "Our contention is that if the business was down, what was the need to issue so many offer letters to these freshers?"

Colleges say some firms have intimidated them of a delay in joining dates, while others have kept them hanging. However, firms have a different view. "TCS has always honoured every offer of employment made and will continue to do so. As is the case every year, we onboard trainees in a staggered manner across quarters in line with demand. We have commenced onboarding of trainees starting Q1FY24 and will continue to have batches joining us on a quarterly basis," says Girish Nandimath, Global Head of Talent Acquisition & Academic Interface of TCS. Harshvendra Soin, Global Chief People Officer and Head of Marketing at Tech Mahindra, without mentioning a timeline, says: "We have already started the onboarding process for last year's campus selects, and joining will start in multiple batches." Wipro, Infosys, Cognizant, Capgemini, HCL, LTI-Mindtree and Mphasis did not respond to BT's queries.

IT Industry body Nasscom's Senior VP and Chief Strategy Officer Sangeeta Gupta says, "Everybody thought the acceleration in tech spending post-Covid-19 was the new normal, but the global environment shifted and you rec-

RISE AND FALL

Hiring count of freshers in the IT industry over the years



*Projected

Source TeamLease Digital, Industry

₹3.5-4

LAKH PER ANNUM

THE LEVEL AT WHICH FRESHERS' SALARIES AT IT SERVICES FIRMS HAVE STAGNATED OVER THE PAST DECADE

6-9

MONTHS

THE DURATION OF MANDATORY TRAINING FRESHERS UNDERGO BEFORE BEING DEPLOYED INTO IT PROJECTS

5.4

MILLION

THE NUMBER OF PEOPLE EMPLOYED BY THE TECH INDUSTRY, A LARGE MAJORITY OF WHOM ARE IN IT SERVICES

1.5

MILLION

THE NUMBER OF ENGINEERS WHO GRADUATE EVERY YEAR IN INDIA. THE IT SECTOR TYPICALLY ABSORBS 20-25 PER CENT OF THEM